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LETTER OF TRANSMITTAL

House of Representatives
Committee on Science and
Astronautics

Washington, D. C.

24 March, 1961

Honorable Overton Brooks
Chairman, Committee on Science and Astronautics

Dear Mr. Chairman:

I am forwarding herewith for committee consideration a report on "Proposed Studies on the Implications of Peaceful Space Activities for Human Affairs." This report was prepared for NASA under a contract with The Brookings Institution; it has been reviewed by members of the committee staff.

The report is an important effort of the executive branch to comply with section 102(c) of the National Aeronautics and Space Act of 1958 in regard to identification of the long-range goals of the national space program and the gaging of their effect on American society. It is felt

therefore, that the study and dissemination of the report for committee purposes will be useful. Of course, there is no implication here that the report necessarily reflects the views of any member of the committee or staff.

Sincerely Yours,

Charles F. Ducander,
Executive Director and Chief Counsel.

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SUMMARY -- ATTITUDES AND VALUES -- THE GENERAL PUBLIC -- PARA. 4:

Though intelligent or semi-intelligent life conceivably exists elsewhere in our solar system, if intelligent extra-terrestrial life is discovered in the next 20 years, it will very probably be by radio telescope from other solar systems. Evidences of its existence might also be found in artifacts left on the moon or other planets. The consequences for attitudes and values are unpredictable, but would vary profoundly in different cultures and between groups within complex societies. A crucial factor would be the nature of the communication between us and the other beings. Whether or not earth would be inspired to an all-out space effort by such a discovery is moot: societies sure of their own place in the universe have disintegrated when confronted by a superior society, and others have survived even though changed. Clearly, the better we can come to understand the factors involved in responding to such crises the better prepared we will be.

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